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LETTERS TO MY SON

*Twenty-one letters every son should read — on
discipline, time, wealth, silence and character.*

Father

A father's letters, worth keeping.

A word before you begin

My son,

What follows is not advice shouted from a stage. It is a set of quiet letters, the kind a father leaves so his son need not learn everything the hard way.

Read one a day. Sit with it. Let it change one small thing in how you live. That is worth more than reading them all in an hour and keeping none.

Everything here is drawn from men far wiser than me — and tested against my own mistakes.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

You learn men in the room, not in the quiet of your study.

Books give you knowledge; people give you wisdom. Close the book sometimes and watch.

Read the world as carefully as you read the page.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

A fool flatters; a wise man observes.

Praise costs nothing and means even less. Watch what a man does when praise is gone.

Trust the eyes, not the tongue.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Spend your evenings among men worth becoming.

The company you keep tonight is the man you become next year.

Choose the room before you choose the words.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

You will never have less time than you do today.

Every year the hours cost more and buy less. Spend the cheap ones now, on what matters.

Begin before the price goes up.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Do now what you would otherwise do badly later, in a hurry.

Whatever is worth doing is worth doing well — and what is worth doing well is worth your full attention now.

Half-done is a debt you pay twice.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Cheerful poverty is an honourable thing.

It is not the man who has too little, but the man who craves more, who is poor.

Want less, and you are already richer than most.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Set aside each day to face the things you fear.

Rehearse loss while you still have everything, and loss
loses its power over you.

Practice the hard day on the easy one.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

We suffer more in imagination than in reality.

Half your dread is for things that never arrive. Meet the real trouble; ignore the rehearsed one.

Carry only the weight that is actually on your back.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

A family's fortune rarely survives three generations: one builds, one keeps, one forgets.

Money is the easiest capital to pass on and the easiest to lose. Character is the hard kind — and the kind that lasts.

Hand down the habits, not just the holdings.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Read deeply, not widely.

A mind scattered across a hundred books holds none of them.

Sit with few authors until they become part of you.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Withdraw into yourself as much as you can.

Crowds undo a man slowly. Keep company with the few who make you better, and with your own thoughts.

Guard your solitude; it is where you are repaired.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Manners open more doors than talent ever will.

The gifted man with no grace dies unknown. The gracious man with little gift is welcomed everywhere.

Polish the way you treat people; it carries you further than skill.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

People judge you in the first minute and rarely revise it.

Your manner speaks before your mouth does. Make the first silence say something good.

Walk in as the man you wish to be seen as.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

The hours you idle away in youth send the bill in old age.

No man ever wished, at the end, that he had wasted more mornings.

Guard the early hours; they are the seed of the late ones.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Idleness is the most exhausting thing a young man can do.

A mind with nothing to chase turns and devours itself.

Give it a worthy hunt.

Tire yourself on purpose, or be tired by accident.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

No man is poor who has enough; no man is rich who fears losing it.

Wealth is measured by what you can do without, not what you have stored.

Own your needs before you chase your wants.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

It is not that we have a short time to live, but that we waste much of it.

Most men are busy with everything except living. Do not be most men.

Spend your days on your life, not on distractions from it.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Drunkenness is nothing but a state of self-induced madness.

Every escape you pour or scroll or chase leaves you further from the thing you fled.

Face the evening sober; that is where strength is built.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

The real wealth of a family is its people, not its money.

Bank accounts empty. What endures is the human, intellectual, and moral capital you grow in your children.

Invest in the person; the portfolio is downstream.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

Knowledge of the world is gained among people, not in the study alone.

Books give you the map; the street teaches you to walk it.

Close the book sometimes and watch.

Yours faithfully,

Father

My dear son,

The crowd is the worst company a growing man can keep.

You become an average of the noise you let in. Let in less.

Step out of the herd to remember your own pace.

Yours faithfully,

Father

Keep going

If these letters served you, there is more.

- A new letter every day on Instagram — @letters_to_son_eng
- The weekly letter, straight to you — comment LETTERS to join.
- The full collection and printed keepsakes — coming soon.

Carry these well. One day you may write your own.

Yours faithfully,

Father